

receiving as much as eighty dollars a day using more than two dozen variations of his first and last name.

In this case, authorities concluded that the people involved in raising money for their schools had no intention of breaking the law, so they were simply ordered by the Postal Service to cease and desist the questionable activities.

Another school in the same corner of Iowa doing the same type of fundraising faced a similar inspection from postal authorities, but didn't get into trouble. What was the difference in the two programs? That Iowa school had adhered to the one rebate per family rule, and never altered or duplicated names or addresses to get the refunds.

It wasn't long before refund conventions also became the target of sting operations. In the fall of 1993, a US Postal inspector and state policemen armed with a search warrant walked into a Kanona, New York, refund convention where thirty-one people were about to enjoy lunch. Exactly what were they looking for? They were searching for materials being used for forgery and mail fraud.

Shaken convention attendees were questioned and their refund forms and proofs of purchase confiscated. The postal inspectors had to rent a Ryder truck to remove all the boxes, files, suitcases, and cash registers. Yes, cash registers. Information netted from a computer at the Coupon Information Center in Alexandria, Virginia, had prompted the raid. In 1992, the computer began showing unusual statistics for refund redemption in the Kanona zip code area. The town boasted a staggering 185 times the national